Aspiration of the Sublime Golden Light, King of Sūtras

Suvarṇaprabhāsottamasūtrendrarājapraṇidhāna · Toh 4379 · Derge Tengyur
གསེར་འོད་དམ་པ་མདོ་སྡེའི་དབང་པོའི་སྨོན་ལམ

The Aspiration of the Sublime Golden Light, King of Sūtras, known in Tibetan as Gser 'od dam pa mdo sde'i dbang po'i smon lam, is a verse prayer drawn from the celebrated Golden Light Sūtra, whose Sanskrit title is Suvarṇaprabhāsottama. After paying homage to the Three Jewels, it invokes the sound of the great drum of the Golden Light, an image from the sūtra itself. It prays that this sound will still the sufferings of the lower realms, of the Lord of Death, and of poverty throughout the trichiliocosm. It also asks that beings be freed from delusion and fear, and that they come to possess the qualities of meditative absorption and the limbs of awakening, just as the Buddha does. This aspiration is Toh 4379 in the Tengyur, where it belongs among the collected aspiration prayers, a class of devotional verses dedicated to the welfare and awakening of all beings.

Here is the Aspiration of the Sublime Golden Light, King of Sūtras.

Homage to the Three Jewels.

By the sound of the great drum of the Sublime Golden Light,
in this trichiliocosm, in these three worlds,
may the sufferings of the lower realms, the sufferings of Yama (the Lord of Death),
and the sufferings of poverty, may all suffering be stilled.
By the sound and voice of this great drum,
may all the delusion of the world be stilled.
Just as the fearless Lord of Sages has stilled all fear,
may beings be fearless and free from fear.
Just as in saṃsāra the omniscient Lord of Sages
possesses all the qualities of the noble ones,
may all creatures possess the qualities
of samādhi and the limbs of awakening, and become oceans of good qualities.
By the sound and voice of this great drum,
may all sentient beings come to have the voice of Brahmā.
May they touch the supreme awakening of a sublime buddha.
May they turn the virtuous wheel of Dharma.
May they remain for inconceivable eons.

May they teach the Dharma for the benefit of beings.
May afflictions be vanquished and suffering dispelled.
May attachment, aversion and delusion be stilled.
Those sentient beings who dwell in the lower realms,
where flames blaze fiercely upon their bones,
may they hear the proclamation of the great drum.
Their sufferings all utterly stilled,
may they hear the words "Homage to the Buddha."
May all sentient beings remember their births
through hundreds of lives, through thousands of millions of lives.
Ever mindful of the Lord of Sages,
may they hear his vast speech.
By the sound and voice of this great drum,
may they find constant companionship with the buddhas.
May they utterly abandon evil deeds.
May they practice virtuous actions.
Whatever the thoughts and aspirations
of humans, of gods, and of all living creatures,
by the sound and voice of this great drum,
may all their hopes be fulfilled.
Those sentient beings born in the unbearable hells,
their bodies blazing everywhere with flames,
without refuge, grieving, wandering about,
may those fires be stilled without remainder.
In the hells, among the hungry ghosts, and in the human world,
whatever unbearable and fierce sufferings beings have,
by the sound and voice of this great drum,
may all their sufferings be stilled.
Those who are without support,
without allies, and without refuge,
for them may I become a protector,
an ally, and a supreme support.

You buddhas, sublime among two-legged beings,
whose minds are endowed with love and compassion,
who dwell in the worlds of the ten directions,
I pray you, consider me.

Whatever exceedingly terrible evil deeds
I have committed in the past,
I come before the Ten-Powered Ones
and confess them all.

Whatever evil I have done
by not regarding my parents as parents,
by not regarding the buddhas as buddhas,
and by not regarding virtue as virtue;
whatever evil I have done
through the conceit of wealth and intoxication,
through intoxication with lineage and possessions,
and through the conceit of youth's intoxication;
whatever evil I have done
through wrongdoing or wrongful speech,
through deeds done wrongly,
and by not looking at the faults of wrongdoing;
whatever evil I have done
by acting with a childish mind,
with a mind darkened by ignorance,
under the sway of evil friends,
with a mind agitated by afflictions,
under the sway of play and pleasure,
under the sway of grief and illness,
and through the fault of never being satisfied with wealth;
whatever evil I have done
through following ignoble people,
through the deceit of jealousy and avarice,
and through the faults of guile and poverty;
whatever evil I have done
at times when want arose,
through desires and causes of fear,
and through not being wealthy;
whatever evil I have done
under the sway of a fickle mind,
under the sway of desire and anger,
and tormented by hunger and thirst;

whatever evil I have done
for the sake of food and drink,
for the sake of women and clothing,
through the many drinks of affliction;
the evil of body, speech and mind,
the threefold misconduct I have amassed,
whatever I have done in such ways,
all of it I confess.

Whatever disrespect I have shown
to the buddhas and to the Dharma,
and likewise to the śrāvakas,
all of it I confess.
Whatever disrespect I have shown
to the pratyekabuddhas
and to the bodhisattvas,
all of it I confess.
The disrespect I have shown
to those who teach the sacred Dharma,
and my lack of respect for the Dharma itself,
all of it I confess.
Having always, through ignorance,
abandoned the sacred Dharma,
and having been disrespectful to my parents,
all of it I confess.
Whatever I have done in foolishness and childishness,
obscured by attachment, aversion and delusion,
and by pride and arrogance,
all of it I confess.

May I, throughout the worlds of the ten directions,
make offerings to the Ten-Powered Ones.
May I deliver the sentient beings of the ten directions
from every suffering.
May I establish all sentient beings, beyond conception,
upon the ten grounds.
And having dwelt upon the ten grounds,
may they all become tathāgatas.

Until I am able to bring all of them
to the end of the ocean of suffering,
may I practise for ten million eons
for the sake of each and every being.
May this sūtra called Supreme Golden Light,
which purifies every karma
and teaches what is profound,
be taught to those beings.
Whoever has committed, through thousands of eons,
misdeeds exceedingly terrible,
by confessing them fully even once,
will have all of them purified.
By the virtue of the Supreme Golden Light,
through which obscurations of karma
are quickly and completely exhausted,
having made these confessions,
may I dwell upon the ten grounds,
the ten supreme sources of jewels.
May the qualities of the buddhas shine forth.
May I deliver beings from the ocean of existence.
Through the flowing river of the buddhas' ocean,
that profound ocean of qualities,
through the inconceivable qualities of the buddhas,
may I bring omniscience to perfection.
Through hundreds of thousands of samādhis,
through inconceivable dhāraṇīs,
through the faculties, the powers and the limbs of awakening,
may I become a supreme Ten-Powered One.

Buddhas, with your attentive minds,
please look upon me.
With your minds endowed with compassion,
please accept my wrongdoing.
Because of the misdeeds I committed
in the past through hundreds of eons,
my mind is full of sorrow,
tormented by misery, grief and fear.

I am afraid of evil deeds;
my mind is always downcast.
Wherever it is I go,
nowhere do I find any joy.
All buddhas, endowed with compassion,
dispellers of the fears of all beings,
please accept my wrongdoing;
free me from my fears.
Tathāgatas, remove the stains
left by my afflictions and my karma.
Buddhas, I pray you,
wash me with the water of compassion.
I confess all my misdeeds.
Whatever I have done in the past,
and whatever misdeeds I commit now,
all of them I confess.
From all wrong actions
I shall restrain myself hereafter.
Whatever wrong I have done,
I shall not conceal that misdeed.
The three kinds of bodily action,
the four kinds of speech,
and the three kinds of mind,
all of them I confess.
What I have done with the body, the actions of speech,
and what I have conceived in the mind,
the ten actions that I have committed,
all of them I confess.
Having abandoned the ten nonvirtuous actions
and taken up the ten virtues,
may I dwell upon the ten grounds
and become a supreme Ten-Powered One.
Whatever evil actions of mine
will bring about unwanted results,
having come before the buddhas,
all of them I confess.

Whoever, here in this Jambudvīpa
and in other world systems,
performs virtuous actions,
in all their virtue I rejoice.
Whatever merit I have accomplished
with body, speech and mind,
by that root of virtue
may I attain supreme awakening.

Whatever exceedingly terrible misdeeds I have done
with a childish mind amid the perils of existence and the destinies,
having come before the matchless Ten-Powered Ones,
each of those misdeeds I confess one by one.
Through the perils of birth, the perils of existence,
the perils of the world, the perils of the fickle mind,
and the various perils of bodily conduct,
whatever misdeeds I have amassed, I confess.
The perilous afflictions of a childish fool,
the perils of meeting with evil companions,
the perils of existence, the perils of attachment,
the perils of the darkness of aversion and delusion,
the perils of weariness, the perils of the times,
and the perils in accumulating merit, whatever I have done in them,
having come into the direct presence of the matchless Victors,
each of those misdeeds I confess one by one.

To the buddhas, golden-hued, shining like a mountain, like Mount Meru,
like an ocean of qualities, I pay homage.
In those Victors I take refuge;
to all those Victors I bow my head.
Golden in hue, golden, with the light of stainless gold,
with limbs and eyes like stainless, utterly pure beryl,
the buddha-sun is the source of blazing glory, splendour and fame;
with the rays of compassion it dispels darkness and gloom.
Your limbs are perfectly stainless, beautiful with lovely light;
buddha-sun, your limbs are suffused as with stainless gold.
Those whose minds are tormented by the fire of afflictions, as by a blazing fire,
the moon of the Sage refreshes with its net of rays.
The thirty-two supreme marks beautify your faculties and limbs;

the excellent minor marks adorn your limbs.
With a net of rays born of blazing glory, splendour and merit,
you abide in the three worlds like the sun amid darkness.
Like stainless, vast, many-coloured beryl,
your limbs are ruddy like the red of dawn, like silver and crystal.
Well adorned with nets of rays of every kind,
Great Sage, by these you are beautiful like the sun.
For those fallen into the great river of saṃsāra, the stream of destitution,
with its waves that sweep across the waters of death churned up by sorrow,
the ocean of suffering, exceedingly harsh and violent,
is dried up by the many rays of the sun of the Sugata (the Buddha).
Your limbs shine with the colour of gold;
source of wisdom, supreme protector of the three worlds,
your limbs adorned with the most beautiful marks,
to the Buddha's blazing golden body I pay homage.

Just as the water of the ocean is measureless,
just as the specks of dust on the earth are endless,
just as the rocks of Mount Meru are beyond compare,
just as the bounds of space are endless,
so too the qualities of the buddhas are endless;
no sentient being is able to know them.
Even if one measured and pondered them for many eons,
one could not know the limit of their qualities.

The waters of the oceans, with their rocks and their mountains,
measured out at the tip of a single hair,
might perhaps be counted, given aeons of reckoning;
but the farthest limit of a buddha's qualities cannot be known.

With such qualities, complexion, renown and fame,
a body adorned with the virtuous major marks,
and adorned with the eighty excellent minor marks,
may all sentient beings become like that.

By these virtuous deeds of mine,
may I before long become a buddha in the world.
May I teach the Dharma for the benefit of beings,
and may I free sentient beings tormented by many sufferings.

May I conquer Māra with his might and his hosts,
and may I turn the virtuous wheel of Dharma.
May I remain for inconceivable aeons,
and may I satisfy sentient beings with the water of nectar.

Just as the Victors of the past perfected them,
may I perfect the six unsurpassed perfections.
May I vanquish the afflictions and dispel suffering,
and may I pacify attachment, aversion and delusion.

Through hundreds of lives, through a thousand ten-millions of lives,
may I always remember my former lives.
May I always remember the Lords of Sages,
and may I hear their vast speech.

By these virtuous deeds of mine,
may I always find the company of the buddhas.
May I utterly give up evil deeds,
and may I practice the virtues that are the source of good.

In all the fields, may all living creatures,
throughout the worlds, have every suffering pacified.
Sentient beings whose faculties are incomplete, whose limbs are impaired,
may each and every one of them have their faculties made whole.

Those stricken with disease, weak, their bodies broken,
who in the ten directions have no refuge,
may all of them swiftly be freed from disease,
and may they gain health, strength and sound faculties.

Those threatened by kings, robbers, thieves and enemies, on the brink of execution,
afflicted by hundreds of varied kinds of suffering,
sentient beings in desperate plight, all those who suffer,
may they be freed from those hundreds of supreme and unbearable terrors.

Those who are beaten, bound in fetters and tormented,
who dwell amid every kind of hardship,
who are stirred up by many thousands of afflictions
and meet with unbearable fear and every kind of grief,
may all of them be freed from their fetters.

May those who are beaten be freed from beatings.
May those condemned to die keep their lives.
May all who are in hardship be without fear.

Sentient beings tormented by hunger, craving and thirst,
may they obtain all kinds of food and drink.
May the blind see all kinds of forms,
and may the deaf hear pleasing sounds.
May the naked obtain all kinds of clothing,
and may poor sentient beings find treasures.
With wealth, grain and many kinds of jewels,
may all sentient beings be endowed with happiness.

May no one be harmed by painful feeling.
May all sentient beings be lovely to behold,
of fine form, beautiful and most auspicious.
May they always gather many joys.
Food and drink as the mind desires, abundance and merit,
may these be accomplished the moment they are thought of.

Clay drums, hand drums and lutes with sweet sounds,
springs, ponds, pools and lakes,
golden lotuses and many-petaled blue lotuses,
food, drink, clothing, wealth, pearls, gems and precious things,
ornaments, gold, every kind of jewel and beryl,
may these be accomplished the moment they are thought of.

May the sound of suffering arise nowhere in the world.
May not a single sentient being be seen in discord.
May all of them have vast radiance of complexion,
and may they shine upon one another.

Whatever excellences there are in the human world,
may they arise for them as they wish.
May every wish, the very moment it is thought,
be fulfilled completely as the fruit of merit.

Incense, garlands and ointments,
clothing, powders and every kind of flower,
may these rain down from the trees at the three times of day,
and may sentient beings take them and rejoice.

To all the inconceivable tathāgatas,
to the perfect bodhisattvas and the śrāvakas,
and to the Dharma that is taught, free of dust and stainless,
may they make offerings in the ten directions.

May they give up all the lower destinies.
May they pass beyond the eight unfree states.
May they attain the sublime king of freedoms.
May they always gain the company of the buddhas.

May they always be born into high families.
May their treasuries be filled with wealth and grain.
With renown and fame, with form and complexion,
may they be well adorned for many aeons.

May all women always become men,
heroic and courageous, learned and clear-minded.
May all of them always practice for the sake of awakening,
and may they practice the six perfections.

In the ten directions, at the foot of lordly jewel trees,
may they see the buddhas seated at ease
upon thrones of precious beryl,
and may they hear the Dharma that they teach.

The evil deeds that I have committed,
whatever I committed before in the perilous realms of existence,
whatever evil deeds have brought unwanted results,
may they all be exhausted without remainder.

All sentient beings who dwell bound in existence,
tightly bound by the noose and rope of saṃsāra,
may their bonds be loosened by the hand of wisdom,
and may they gain freedom from sufferings.

Sentient beings here in this land of Jambudvīpa,
and those in other world systems,
who perform the many kinds of profound merit,
in all of them I rejoice.

By the merit of my rejoicing,
accomplished with body, speech and mind,
may my aspirations bear fruit,

and may I attain unsurpassed awakening, free of dust.

Whoever, always free of stain,
with a stainless mind pays homage and praises,
and recites this dedication,
will avoid the lower realms for sixty aeons.

Whoever, among men and women, brahmins and kṣatriyas,
sits with palms joined and praises the Victor
by reciting these verses,
will remember their births in all their lives.

Their bodies will be adorned with every limb and faculty,
endowed with many kinds of merit and good qualities;
kings, lords of men, will always honor them,
and in each and every place they will be like that.

Those into whose ears this confession resounds
have not done virtue in the presence of one buddha alone,
nor of two, nor of four, nor five, nor ten;
rather, they have done virtue in the presence of a thousand buddhas.

Know that all who hear these possess a vast heap of merit, satisfy many people with benefit and happiness, and will have all their obscurations purified. These who are endowed with such distinguished conduct, in times past, praised the tathāgatas and

made vast aspirational prayers as the cause, and it is through the blessing of the Tathāgatas that they hear these.

This completes the aspiration spoken in the noble Sublime Golden Light, King of Sūtras.

Translator's Notes

• "Flames blaze fiercely upon their bones" renders the somewhat unusual phrase literally "in the domain of bones."
• In the line rendered "Those whose minds are tormented by the fire of afflictions," the Tibetan as printed reads med ("without") where mes ("by fire") makes evident sense; I have translated the latter reading. The repeated term rendered "perils" translates a word meaning dangers or dire straits (Skt. likely saṃkaṭa).
• In the stanza on exhausting past evil deeds, the last line reads "may all virtue be exhausted without remainder," which contradicts its context; it is rendered as referring to the evil deeds, reading the text as "may they all," which is evidently intended. The phrase rendered

"abundance" in "abundance and merit" is used here in its ordinary sense, not as the name Subhūti.
• The piece begins mid-sentence. The full sentence, with the previous piece, reads: "Those endowed with such special conduct hear these because in the past they praised the Tathāgatas and made vast aspirational prayers, and through the blessing of the Tathāgatas." In the colophon the Tibetan title adds "king" after "lord of sūtras." It is rendered with the established title "King of Sūtras" to keep the name the same throughout.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.